Rachel Freedman

Reward learning · AI alignment · Interpretability
Pluralistic alignment · Social choice theory · RLHF

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Education

late 2019 – present *expected Spring 2027*
Artificial Intelligence PhD, *UC Berkeley* — GPA 3.93
I am a **Cooperative AI Foundation PhD Fellow**, part of BAIR (Berkeley AI Research) and CHAI (Center for Human-Compatible AI), and advised by Professor Stuart Russell.

2013 – 2017
Computer Science/Psychology BA, *Duke University* — GPA 3.93
I graduated **Phi Beta Kappa** and ***magna cum laude***, and earned **High Distinction in Computer Science** for my research thesis (published in the journal Artificial Intelligence)

2015 – 2016
CS/Philosophy Registered Visiting Student, *Oxford University* — GPA 3.93
I founded the AI safety student society at Future of Humanity Institute.

2011 – 2017
Part-Time Student, *UNC Chapel Hill* — GPA 4.00

Publications

Lead author

[1] **Rachel Freedman**, Justin Svegliato, Kyle Wray, Stuart Russell. "Active Teacher Selection for Reward Learning." *TMLR* 2026. Contributed talks at *PRL at AAAI 2025* and *TAIS 2025*.

[2] **Rachel Freedman**. "Adaptive Pluralistic Alignment: A Pipeline for Dynamic Artificial Democracy." *BiAlign Workshop at NeurIPS 2026* (oral, top 15%). Also presented at *Pluralistic Alignment Workshop at ICML 2026*.

[3] **Rachel Freedman**, Jana Schaich Borg, Walter Sinnott-Armstrong, John Dickerson, Vincent Conitzer. "Adapting a Kidney Exchange Algorithm to Align with Human Values." *Artificial Intelligence, v. 283*, 2020. Also presented at *AAAI 2018*, *AIES 2018*, *MD4SG 2018*, and *Participatory ML workshop at ICML 2020*. *(100+ citations)*
✱ Outstanding Student Paper Honorable Mention at AAAI 2018

[4] **Rachel Freedman**, Rohin Shah, Anca Dragan. "Choice Set Misspecification in Reward Inference." *Workshop on Artificial Intelligence Safety at IJCAI 2020*. ✱ Best Paper Award

Supervising author

[5] Mohamed I. Eldagla, Ifesi Onubogu, Prerana Rane, Harsh Sharma, **Rachel Freedman**. "Reward Basis Decomposition for Interpreting Preference Heterogeneity." *InterpScience Workshop at NeurIPS* 2026.

[6] Henry Papadatos, **Rachel Freedman**. "Linear Probe Penalties Reduce LLM Sycophancy." *Socially Responsible Language Modelling Research Workshop (SoLaR) at NeurIPS 2024*.

[7] Peter Barnett, **Rachel Freedman**, Justin Svegliato, Stuart Russell. "Active Reward Learning from Multiple Teachers." *SafeAI at AAAI 2023*. ✱ Best Paper Award Finalist

[8] Oliver Daniels-Koch, **Rachel Freedman**. "The Expertise Problem: Learning from Specialized Feedback." *ML Safety Workshop at NeurIPS 2022*. ✱ AI Risk Analysis Award

Contributing author

[9] Vincent Conitzer, **Rachel Freedman**, Jobst Heitzig, Wesley H. Holliday, Bob M. Jacobs, Nathan Lambert, Milan Mossé, Eric Pacuit, Stuart Russell, Hailey Schoelkopf, Emanuel Tewolde, William S. Zwicker. "Social Choice for AI Alignment: Dealing with Diverse Human Feedback." *ICML 2024*. *(100+ citations)*

[10] Stephen Casper, [...], **Rachel Freedman**, [...], Dylan Hadfield-Menell. "Open Problems and Fundamental Limitations of Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback." *ICLR 2025*. Also in *TMLR*. *(1,000+ citations)*

[11] Rohin Shah, Pedro Freire, Neel Alex, **Rachel Freedman**, Dmitrii Krasheninnikov, Lawrence Chan, Michael Dennis, Pieter Abbeel, Anca Dragan, Stuart Russell. "Benefits of Assistance over Reward Learning." *Cooperative AI Workshop at NeurIPS 2020*. ✱ Best Paper Award

Research & Work Experience

2019 – present **Berkeley PhD Researcher**, *CHAI lab*, UC Berkeley
- Research topics include AI Alignment, reward learning, RLHF, interpretability, LLM capability evaluation, and pluralistic alignment in support of robustly beneficial and safe AI
- Mentored 9 junior researchers, who have gone to lead AI safety non-profits (Henry Papadatos, SaferAI), work at leading AI safety non-profits (Peter Barnett, MIRI), and pursue PhDs in the area (Pavel Czempin, USC; Oliver Daniels, UMass Amherst)
- Contributed technical feedback to reports for the United Nations and the World Economic Forum and to books including The Alignment Problem (by Brian Christian) and Moral AI (by Borg, Conitzer and Sinnott-Armstrong)
- Advised by Prof. Stuart Russell, part of the Center for Human-Compatible AI (CHAI)

2026 – present **Scientific Advisor (consultant)**, *AEsona*, Remote
- Advise on individual alignment research

2022 – present **AI Safety Career Advisor (contractor)**, *80,000 Hours*, Remote
- Advised >200 participants across 5 continents on AI safety research and careers
- Conducted regular group calls to answer questions from global participants

2023 **Cambridge Visiting Researcher**, *Krueger lab*, Cambridge University
- Collaborated with Prof. David Krueger, Computational and Biological Learning Lab
- Researched reducing causal confusion in reward learning from human feedback

2017 – 2019 **Software Engineer and Consultant**, *Galatea Associates*, London, UK
- Collaborated with international team of consultants, engineers, contractors and stakeholders to manage ever-changing business problems and constraints
- Learned new tools and languages rapidly as required

2016 – 2017 **Moral AI Researcher**, *Moral AI lab*, Duke University
- Conducted a year-long independent research project incorporating computer science and psychology methodologies into the field of artificial morality
- Adapted a kidney exchange algorithm to align with human values by modeling underlying frameworks in human responses to moral dilemmas
- Awarded High Distinction for my thesis research; presented and published this work at AAAI 2018, where it won Outstanding Student Paper Honorable Mention
- Published in Artificial Intelligence, poster presented at AIES 2018 and MD4SG 2018.

Summer 2015 **Software Engineering Intern**, *Microsoft*, Seattle, US

2013 – 2014 **Psychology and Neuroscience Research Assistant**, *Duke University*

Honors & Awards

Conferences & Workshops

2023 **Best Paper Award Finalist**, SafeAI Workshop at AAAI

2022 **AI Risk Analysis Award**, ML Safety Workshop at NeurIPS

2020–21 **Ambassador**, Effective Altruism Global

2020 **Best Paper Award**, CoopAI Workshop at NeurIPS
Best Paper Award, AISafety Workshop at IJCAI-PRICAI

2018 **Outstanding Student Paper Hon. Mention**, AAAI

Undergraduate

2017 **Phi Beta Kappa**, Duke University
magna cum laude, Duke University
High Distinction in Computer Science, Duke University

Graduate

2025 **Cooperative AI PhD Fellowship**, Cooperative AI Foundation

2024 **Long Term Future Fund Grant**, EA Funds
Foresight Fellowship, Foresight Institute

2023 **Manifund Grant**, Manifund

2021 **Rising Star in AI Ethics**, Women in AI Ethics

2019 **EECS Excellence Award**, UC Berkeley
EECS Departmental Fellowship, UC Berkeley

Other

2019 **Gates Cambridge Finalist**, Gates Cambridge Trust

2017 **Rhodes Scholarship Finalist**, Rhodes Trust

2013–17 **Robertson Scholarship**, Robertson Scholarship Leadership Program

2013–16 **Thomas J. Watson Memorial Scholarship**, IBM

2013 **President's Volunteer Service Gold Award**, US Government

Invited Talks & Panels

2026
- Amplified Oversight, *Goodfire, Women in Frontier AI series*
- Learning from Diverse Teachers, *Oxford BOLD*
- Introduction to AI Safety and Ethics, *Social Choice for AI Workshop*
- Reward Model Personalization, *Center for Human-Compatible AI*

2025
- Misspecification Failures in RLHF, *London Initiative for Safe AI*
- Social Choice for AI Alignment, *Center for Human-Compatible AI*

2024
- Limitations of RLHF, *Stanford CS362 guest lecture*
- Aligning AI to Diverse Principals, *Foresight Institute Vision Weekend*
- Social Choice for AI Alignment, *Institutional Economics (SIOE) Conference*
- Social Choice for RLHF, *Cooperative AI Summer School lecture*
- Reinforcement Learning from Human Feedback, *Stanford E338 guest lecture*
- RLHF: Problems and Approaches, *Stanford Existential Risk Symposium*
- Open Problems in RLHF, *ATHENA seminar series*

2023
- Panel on AI and Business Growth, *Factory Venture Conference*
- Active Teacher Selection, *Cambridge University Krueger Lab*

2022
- Value Alignment, *Institute for Advanced Study WAM program*
- My Approach to Alignment Research, *SERI MATS seminar series*
- Reward Modeling and Human Model Misspecification, *CHAI Workshop*
- Panel on AI, *Duke University Career Center*

2021
- Panel on Graduate School, *AI Safety Support*

Service & Leadership

since 2022
- AI Safety Advisor (contractor), *80,000 Hours*

2026
- Program Advisor, *PRISM AI Safety Research Fellowship*
- Grant Advisor (Multi-Agent Safety), *Schmidt Sciences*
- Stream Mentor, *PRISM AI Safety Fellowship*
- Program Committee, *AAAI 2026 AI Alignment Track (AAAI-AIA26)*
- Conference Reviewer, *International Association for Safe and Ethical AI (IASEAI27)*
- Workshop Reviewer, *NeurIPS InterpScience Workshop*

2025
- Conference Reviewer, *International Association for Safe and Ethical AI (IASEAI26)*
- Program Committee, *AAAI 2025 AI Alignment Track (AAAI-AIA25)*

2024
- Conference Reviewer, *Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS)*
- Program Committee, *ECAI Workshop on Social Choice for AI Ethics and Safety*

2022
- Workshop Reviewer, *NeurIPS ML Safety Workshop (MLSW22)*
- Journal Reviewer, *Journal of Artificial Intelligence (JAIR)*

2021
- Program Committee, *IJCAI Workshop on Artificial Intelligence Safety* (NYC, US)

2019–21
- Ambassador, *Effective Altruism Global Conferences* (London, UK and San Francisco, US)

2015–16
- Co-founder and President, *Oxford Existential Risk Society* (Oxford, UK)

Advising & Mentoring

2026
- **Team Mentor**, PRISM AI Safety Research Fellowship → *NeurIPS InterpScience Workshop* (later: OpenAI Safety Fellowship, others)

2024–25
- **Pavel Czempin**, CHAI Intern → *RSS 2025 Workshop CRLH* (later: PhD at USC)

2023–24
- **Henry Papadatos**, EPFL MSc → *NeurIPS SoLaR Workshop* (later: Leads SaferAI)

2022–23
- **Peter Barnett**, CHAI Intern → *AAAI Workshop (Award Finalist)* (later: MIRI)
- **Oliver Daniels-Koch**, CHAI Intern → *NeurIPS Workshop (Award)* (later: PhD at UMass Amherst)

Skills & Interests

Programming	Claude Code, Python, NumPy, PyTorch, Java, Julia, Git; extensive practice learning new technologies quickly and proactively via engineering and consulting work
Service	Mentor young people seeking a career in AI (particularly those from underrepresented backgrounds) for >5 years · Volunteer at the Berkeley public animal shelter (2 years) · Tutored and mentored at-risk North Carolina students weekly (2 years, earned the President's Volunteer Service Gold Award) · Volunteered full-time to support students in rural Mississippi (3 months)
Martial Arts	World Taekwondo Federation-certified master black belt (4th degree) in Taekwondo · 2nd degree black belt in Kumdo · Trained, taught and competed for 12 years
Creative Writing	Served as writer-in-residence at artist residency Arte Studio Ginestrelle in Italy · Stories published in Duke, UNC and Oxford University literary publications · Play performed at Duke New Works Festival

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